

Welcome to the Harlem Renaissance at The Mini Museum. This guide gives your family everything you need to explore the exhibition together — conversation starters, recommended books and recordings, activity ideas for home, and context to help the exhibition make sense. No background knowledge needed. Curiosity is enough.

WHAT IS THE HARLEM RENAISSANCE?

A cultural explosion, 100 years ago

Between roughly 1920 and the mid-1930s, the neighborhood of Harlem in New York City became one of the most creative places in the world. Hundreds of Black artists, writers, musicians, and thinkers had moved north from the South during what historians call the Great Migration — escaping the injustice of Jim Crow laws to find better lives in Northern cities. When they found each other in Harlem, something extraordinary happened.

Poets like Langston Hughes wrote about what it meant to be Black and American at the same time. Painters like Aaron Douglas invented a bold new visual language rooted in African art. Musicians like Duke Ellington and Bessie Smith created jazz and blues that would change music forever. Writers like Zora Neale Hurston collected and celebrated the folk traditions that had survived slavery. Together, they created a Renaissance — a rebirth — that insisted, loudly and beautifully, on the dignity and worth of Black life.

KEY PEOPLE TO KNOW

THE ARTISTS

- **Aaron Douglas (1899–1979)** — The leading visual artist of the Renaissance. Known for bold geometric silhouettes, concentric circles of light, and paintings that celebrated African heritage.
- **Zora Neale Hurston (1891–1960)** — Folklorist, novelist, and playwright who collected African American oral traditions across the South.

THE WRITERS AND MUSICIANS

- **Langston Hughes (1902–1967)** — America's most beloved Black poet. His poems sounded like jazz and spoke for working people.
- **Duke Ellington (1899–1974)** — Jazz composer and bandleader whose music defined the Harlem sound.
- **Bessie Smith (1894–1937)** — "The Empress of the Blues" — one of the most powerful voices in American music.

AT THE EXHIBITION

Your child's class visited (or is visiting) the Harlem Renaissance exhibition at The Mini Museum. The exhibition includes interactive displays, an electric phonograph from the 1920s, jazz listening stations, Aaron Douglas reproductions, a Great Migration map, and the Harlem in Words poetry workshop.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

You can explore the full digital exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

TALKING WITH YOUR CHILD

Conversation starters by age

PREK–K

- *"We're going to look at some paintings made a long time ago. The people in the pictures look like shadows — called silhouettes. Can you see them? What do you think they're doing?"*
- *"The artist used circles that look like they're glowing. What do you think the light means?"*

GRADES 1–2

- *"Lots of people moved from the South to Harlem, New York — kind of like moving to a completely new place for a better life. Have you ever moved somewhere new, or do you know someone who has?"*
- *"Langston Hughes wrote poems about what it's like to dream of something better. What's something you dream about?"*

GRADES 3–8

- *"The Harlem Renaissance artists were saying through their art: 'We are here. Our culture is beautiful. We matter.' Why do you think it was important to say that through art, specifically — not through a speech or a law?"*
- *"If you were going to create something — a painting, a poem, a song — that showed who you are and where you come from, what would it look like?"*
- *"Is there something happening in the world today that reminds you of what was happening during the Harlem Renaissance? What would Langston Hughes write about right now?"*

AT HOME: SIMPLE ACTIVITIES

Extend the learning together

01

Listen Together

Find Louis Armstrong's "West End Blues" (1928), Bessie Smith's "Downhearted Blues" (1923), or Duke Ellington's "It Don't Mean a Thing" (1932) on YouTube or Spotify. As you listen, ask: what instrument do you hear? What does the music make you picture? What year do you think this was made?

02

Silhouette Art

Tape black paper over a light source and trace your child's shadow-profile as a silhouette. Let them add a colorful background inspired by Aaron Douglas — concentric circles, geometric patterns, bold colors. Display it alongside a printout of a Douglas painting.

03

Family Poetry

Take turns completing these lines: *"I, too, [describe yourself]... They [something that happened]... But I [how you responded]... Tomorrow, [what you believe will happen]."* This is the structure of Langston Hughes's "I, Too" — one of the most powerful poems in American history.

04

Map the Migration

Find a US map online. Show your child: Mississippi Delta, Memphis, St. Louis, Chicago, New York City. Trace the route. Ask: *"If you had to leave everything and walk this far — what would you take? What would you leave behind?"*

BOOKS FOR EVERY AGE

Recommended reading for families

PICTURE BOOKS — PREK THROUGH GRADE 2

Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince	Andrea Davis Pinkney — Caldecott Honor; a warm, musical introduction to Ellington's life and music
Harlem	Walter Dean Myers / Christopher Myers — a love letter to Harlem in poetry and vibrant illustration; Caldecott Honor
Before She Was Harriet	Lesa Cline-Ransome, illustrated by James E. Ransome — a life told backward in verse
Jazz	Walter Dean Myers — poetry and illustration that captures the sound of jazz for young readers
Ruth and the Green Book	Calvin Alexander Ramsey — the Great Migration and the reality of traveling while Black, told accessibly

MIDDLE GRADE — GRADES 3 THROUGH 6

The Dream Keeper and Other Poems	Langston Hughes — selected poems designed for young readers; the ideal introduction to Hughes
Harlem Stomp!	Laban Carrick Hill — comprehensive, readable history of the Harlem Renaissance with photographs
Stompin' at the Savoy: The Story of Norma Miller	Norma Miller with Alan Govenar — the Lindy Hop and the Savoy Ballroom, told by a dancer who was there
Zora and Me	Victoria Bond / T.R. Simon — fiction inspired by Zora Neale Hurston's childhood; mystery format, excellent
Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes	Selected and illustrated edition with teaching notes; ideal for reading poems aloud together

OLDER READERS — GRADES 7 AND UP

Their Eyes Were Watching God	Zora Neale Hurston — the defining novel of the Harlem Renaissance; one of the great American novels
The Collected Poems of Langston Hughes	The complete poems — dip in anywhere; every poem is accessible and worth re-reading
The Warmth of Other Suns	Isabel Wilkerson — the definitive account of the Great Migration; National Book Critics Circle Award; adult read, excerpts for Gr 8+
The New Negro (1925)	Edited by Alain Locke — the anthology that launched the Renaissance; free via HathiTrust online

ONLINE RESOURCES — FREE

poets.org / poetryfoundation.org	Many Harlem Renaissance poems free, with biographical context and teaching notes
Smithsonian Folkways	Free streaming of Bessie Smith, Louis Armstrong, Duke Ellington, Langston Hughes reading his own poetry
Schomburg Center	schomburgcenter.org — the world's greatest archive of African American culture; free digital resources

FAITH AND THE HARLEM RENAISSANCE

A Catholic perspective for families

The Catholic Church teaches that every human person is made in the image and likeness of God — *imago Dei* — and therefore possesses inherent, irreducible dignity. This is not a social convention; it is a theological claim about the nature of reality. Every person, regardless of race, status, or achievement, is sacred.

The Harlem Renaissance was, at its heart, a sustained affirmation of this truth against a society that refused to acknowledge it. When Langston Hughes wrote "I, too, am America" — he was making a claim that Catholic Social Teaching Principle 1 would affirm unreservedly. When Aaron Douglas painted Black figures as noble, powerful, and spiritually radiant — he was making visible what God had already declared about every human person.

A CONVERSATION FOR CATHOLIC FAMILIES

"The Church teaches that every person is made in God's image. The artists of the Harlem Renaissance were saying the same thing through their art — insisting that the world see what it was refusing to acknowledge. What do you think it takes to keep believing in your own dignity when the world is telling you otherwise? Where did the Harlem Renaissance artists find that strength?"

ABOUT THE MINI MUSEUM

The Mini Museum brings museum-quality experiences directly into student learning. The Harlem Renaissance exhibition includes an original 1920s electric phonograph, interactive jazz and poetry stations, authentic artifacts, Aaron Douglas reproductions, and the digital exhibition portal at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance.

To arrange a family visit, speak with your child's teacher or contact the library directly. Saturday family sessions are available by appointment.

THANK YOU FOR EXPLORING WITH US

The Harlem Renaissance lasted about 20 years. The art it produced has lasted 100. Some of the people who made it are still alive in their work — in the poems your child reads, the music still playing on streaming platforms, the paintings in museum collections around the world. When you explore this with your family, you're joining a conversation that has been going on for a century — and that still has things to say.